

The Person-centred Approach to Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

The aim of this chapter is to provide a guide to person-centred coaching. The chapter will help readers to identify and clarify the philosophical underpinnings of the person-centred approach, the goals and tasks of the person-centred coach, how it relates to other forms of coaching, and contexts in which it is useful.

History and theoretical tradition

The person-centred approach was originally developed by Carl Rogers. Rogers began to develop the person-centered approach during the 1940s and 1950s. Person-centred (or client-centred, as it was known then) refers to the philosophical stance that people are their own best experts. The person-centred approach was seen as an alternative to the then dominant models in American psychology of behaviourism and psychoanalysis, and as such became aligned with the third force in psychology, that of humanistic psychology. Today, Rogers is best remembered for his books *Client-Centered Therapy: Its current practice, implications and theory* (1951) and *On becoming a person: A therapists view of psychotherapy* (1961), both of which have been reprinted numerous times and remain in print and widely read. The person-centred approach is an established psychological tradition supported by over fifty years of research and theory (see Barrett-Lennard, 1998; Kirschenbaum, 2007).

The term person-centred approach is used deliberately to signify that this is an *approach*, not a set of techniques. The person-centred approach can be applied to a range of contexts, from one-to-one settings, in small groups, in community settings, or as applied to social policy (Barrett-Lennard, 1998). In terms of one to one practice, Carl Rogers introduced the term counselling but he might equally well have used the term coaching, because in person-centred practice these terms are interchangeable. The current use of these two terms reflects the prevalent medical model ideology, but person-centred practice is not based in the medical model and so there is no conceptual distinction between coaching and therapy. The practitioner adheres to the same philosophical principle of respecting the self-determination of the other, whether they are practising as a coach or as a therapist. Unlike other therapeutic approaches, person-centred practice is not concerned with ‘repairing’ or ‘curing’ dysfunctionality, and never adopted the ‘diagnostic’ stance of the medical model in which the therapist is the expert. Like coaching, the focus of person-centred counselling has always been to facilitate the self-determination and full functioning of the client.

MAIN ASSUMPTIONS OF THE PERSON-CENTRED APPROACH

The theoretical foundation stone of the person-centred approach is the *actualizing tendency*. The actualizing tendency is defined as a universal human motivation resulting in growth, development, and autonomy of the individual (Rogers, 1959, 1963). It is a biological tendency, not a moral imperative. The metaphor most often used to convey this theoretical principle is how an acorn has the potential to develop into an oak tree, and given the right nutrients from the soil, the right balance of sunlight and shade, it will grow to its fullest potential as an oak tree. But given a lack of nutrients from the soil, the wrong balance of sunlight and shade, its potential as an oak tree will be only partially fulfilled. Thus it is with people, person-centered theory suggests. The term *self-actualization* in person-centred terminology therefore refers to the process of becoming, which can be either in a positive, socially constructive direction or a negative, socially destructive direction, depending on the social environment.

The person-centred approach to helping is based on the above theoretical framework, i.e. that people are intrinsically motivated to grow and develop in the direction of becoming more optimally functioning, when the right social environmental conditions are present. The aim of the client-centred coach is to create facilitative social–environmental conditions, within the context of the coaching relationship, that will enable the client to evaluate experiences organismically, which, put more colloquially, is to hear one’s own inner voice:

individuals have within themselves vast resources for self-understanding, and for altering their self-concepts, basic attitudes, and self-directed behaviour; these resources can be tapped if a definable climate of facilitative psychological attitudes can be provided. (Rogers, 1980: 115)

Rogers (1957a: 96) described six facilitative relationship conditions that he held were necessary and sufficient for positive therapeutic change.

1. Two persons are in psychological contact.
2. The first, whom we shall call the client, is in a state of incongruence, being vulnerable or anxious.
3. The second person, whom we shall call the therapist, is congruent or integrated in the relationship.
4. The therapist experiences unconditional positive regard for the client.
5. The therapist experiences an empathic understanding of the client's internal frame of reference and endeavours to communicate this experience to the client.
6. The communication to the client of the therapist's empathic understanding and unconditional positive regard is to a minimal degree achieved.

Rogers believed these conditions to underlie *any* therapeutic personality change, and thus believed that they must be in operation in any successful helping relationship.

GOALS AND TASKS OF PERSON-CENTRED COACHING

The ideas first associated with the person-centred movement underpin the practice of many coaches. Palmer and Whybrow (2006) found that the majority of coaching psychologists describe themselves as facilitational (67.9%) rather than instructional (17.4%), and that the person-centred approach is one of the most frequently used approaches to coaching. Indeed, although coaching is a new professional movement, the development of coaching and the origin of many of the ideas can be traced back to the humanistic tradition of psychology (Grant, 2008).

Originally, Rogers used the term *non-directivity*, before introducing the term person-centred. The concept of non-directivity has been prone to misunderstanding, with some commentators claiming that it is impossible to have a non-directive relationship. However, this has been clarified by Grant (2004), who distinguished between *principled* non-directivity and *instrumental* non-directivity. Whereas principled non-directivity refers to the therapist's ethical values of non-interference and respect for the self-determination of the other and is itself the goal of the therapist, instrumental non-directivity refers to a set of behaviours applied by the therapist to achieve a particular goal, such as building rapport. Person-centred approaches are founded on principled and not instrumental non-directivity. This serves as the guiding principle for client-centred practice, which in essence is simply the principled stance of respecting the self-determination of others (Grant, 2004).

Client-centered therapists make no assumptions about what people need or how they should be free. They do not attempt to promote self-acceptance, self-direction, positive growth, self-actualization, congruence between real or perceived selves, a particular vision of reality, or anything....*Client-centered therapy is the practice of simply respecting the right to self-determination of others.* (Grant, 2004: 158)

Person-centred psychology is not a set of therapeutic techniques but an attitude based on the theoretical stance that people are their own best experts (Joseph, 2003; Levitt, 2005). As Brodley (2005) wrote:

The non-directive attitude is psychologically profound; it is not a technique. Early in a therapist's development it may be superficial and prescriptive – 'Don't do this' or 'Don't do that'. But with time, self-examination and therapy

experience, it becomes an aspect of the therapist's character. It represents a feeling of profound respect for the constructive potential in persons and great sensitivity to their vulnerability. (2005: 3)

The implication from principled non-directivity is that reflective listening constitutes the majority of responses from the coach:

- Client. I don't know, it's like we don't connect anymore, we don't talk, it's not like it was, she says that everything is ok and that she loves me, but I don't feel loved. I don't know what to do.
- Coach. You feel stuck, not knowing, she says she loves you, but you don't feel loved. You look frightened as you say that.
- Client. Do I? ... I suppose I am, I don't know what to do, if she leaves me, I'll ... I'll, I don't know ...
- Coach. You feel frightened, and when you think about this you are ... lost?
- Client. Abandoned, I don't know if I could cope ...
- Coach. You don't know if you could cope ...
- Client. ... I know I could cope, but I don't want to go through that, I can't face it, but I know that I'll get through in the end (sighs) ... I can't carry on like this either, I can't cope with this ...
- Coach. You are really struggling to manage what's happening right now in your life, all the confusion ... you don't want to separate but you know that you will be able to get through it if you have to ... is that it?
- Client. Yes ... I've got to look after myself ...

In this example of life coaching, the coach is staying with the client's agenda. The coach does not introduce new material, nor prompt the client about how to think about the content of what they say, or what direction to go in. In reflecting to the client that they seem frightened, the coach is staying with what the client is bringing, and in doing so helps the client to become more aware of how they are feeling. It is hard on paper, and with such a snapshot example, to convey the complexity and depth of the relationship that develops between the coach and the client. Reflective listening is not a passive process, it requires attention to all that is said, and all that is not said, and it requires the coach to choose on the basis of their empathic understanding as well as their own congruence in that moment what to reflect on. Reflective listening, when skilfully done, and in the context of an empathic, congruent, positively regarding and unconditional relationship encourages the client to verbalize further, to explore issues in more depth, to be challenged, to reach new insights, and ultimately to be more equipped to make new choices in life.

COMPARISON OF TRADITIONS

There are a variety of other approaches to coaching, and although person-centred coaching has features in common with many of them; such as the shared focus on the relationship with psychodynamic approaches; the client's perceptions with the cognitive approach; the agency of the client with solution focused coaching; the present experiencing with Gestalt coaching; the lack of rigid techniques with existential coaching; the emphasis on optimal functioning with positive psychology; all of these other approaches generally adopt the view that some form of directivity is necessary in the coaching session. The person-centred approach is unique in its adoption of principled non-directivity.

A further distinction is that the person-centred approach adopts a unified and holistic focus on both the negative and the positive aspects of human functioning (Joseph & Worsley, 2005; Joseph & Linley, 2006a). The person-centred approach does not make a distinction between people in terms of their level of psychological functioning, because the process of alleviating distress and dysfunction is the same as that for facilitating well-being and optimal functioning. Psychological functioning is defined in relation to the extent to which self-actualization is congruent with the actualizing tendency (Ford, 1991). When there is greater congruence, greater well-being and more optimal functioning result; but when there is less congruence, greater distress and dysfunction result (see Wilkins, 2005). The development of different terminology, i.e. counselling versus coaching, to describe people at different points on the spectrum of psychological functioning, reflects the pervasive medical model conception that helping people in distress is different from helping people achieve well-being. It must be emphasized that the way in which professional organizations have developed to deal with people at different points on the spectrum ultimately reflects a social construction of human functioning grounded in a medical model and an illness ideology. From the person-centred perspective there is no boundary between coaching and counselling. Thus, person-centred coaching is the same activity requiring the same theoretical base, the same skills, and high level of personal development as required for person-centred counselling. There is no meaningful theoretical distinction from the perspective of the person-centred approach between the process of coaching and that of counselling. In essence both require principled non-directivity within the context of a facilitative relationship.

But this is not to say that an observer would not notice any difference between person-centred coaching and person-centred counselling. Quite simply, what terms we use will determine what clients we work with. If the public understanding is that counselling is about looking back in life at what has gone wrong, whereas coaching is about looking forward to what can go right, different people with different issues will be attracted to counselling than to coaching. Thus, although the task of the person-centred counsellor or coach is the same in either case – to stay with the person and to facilitate the person's process of self determination – at the level of content the sessions would be different, simply because clients are more likely to bring different material to counselling compared to coaching.

SPECIFIC FEATURES, PROCESSES, AND THE ROLE OF THE COACH

A brief fictional example of an exchange during a life coaching session was used above to illustrate the principle of non-directivity (see also Joseph & Bryant-Jefferies, 2008). Life coaching is probably the most obvious arena in which person-centred coaching is applicable. The person-centred approach does not prescribe what the client should do, because it is grounded in the meta-theoretical assumption that people have an inherent tendency toward growth, development, and optimal functioning. The task of the coach is to trust the client to find his or her own direction in life, to hold an attitude of principled non-directivity towards others, and to be a

person who is able to maintain an empathic, congruent, and positively regarding stance towards the other.

Thus it is that person-centred coaching, more so than other approaches that emphasize the techniques of the coach, emphasizes the successful formation of a collaborative relationship (Stober & Grant, 2006; O'Broin & Palmer, 2008), and the coaches' attributes – their authenticity, emotional literacy, and so on – factors which are thought to be important in determining coaching effectiveness (Fillery-Travis & Lane, 2008), as with counselling and psychotherapy (Duncan & Miller, 2000; Wampold, 2001; Bozarth & Motomasa, 2005).

In practice, the person-centred coach strives to understand both the content of what the client is saying and the process they are working through, reflecting back their understanding to the client so that the client has a mirror to his or her experiencing in that moment. This helps the client to hear their own inner voice, to go deeper into their process and become aware of new material that was previously at the edge of their awareness. But at no point does the coach direct the client as to how they ought to be experiencing; his or her role is only to offer the relational conditions within which the client's own process will direct the session.

As noted above, person-centred coaching is not defined by the use of techniques, but by the relationship that develops. However, there is no prohibition of the use of techniques *per se*. There has been much theoretical and practical development in the world of client-centred therapy over recent years (see Sanders, 2004), ranging from the classical client-centred approach to therapy (Merry, 2004); this with its principled role of going with the client at the client's pace, through to more process-directed approaches (Worsley, 2001, 2004), and motivational interviewing, which has its roots in the person-centred approach (Passmore & Whybrow, 2008). What is different about the person-centred way of working is that the techniques, when they are used, become an expression of the meta-theoretical assumptions of person-centred theory (see Joseph & Linley, 2006b). It is not the fact that the coach uses a particular technique or assessment device that is the issue, but *how* they use it. In the above session the coach may introduce the use of various techniques, but the important thing is that they do not violate their principled non-directivity. For example the coach may think it appropriate to offer the suggestion that the client could explore their coping style, perhaps suggesting an appropriate self-help book on the topic, or suggesting to the client that they complete a psychometric test in order to gain insight into their coping style. The coach may choose to offer this because in their judgment they think they have information that the client does not and which could be useful to the client.

Thus, the person-centred coach can draw on and offer to the client various cognitive-behavioural, multimodal, solution-focused, and systems theory techniques (see Kauffman & Scoular, 2004). Cognitive-behavioural psychology, for example offers a wealth of techniques that can be helpful to people in learning about themselves and in exploring the relationship between thoughts and feelings, and learning how what we say to ourselves can hold us back from achieving our goals (Neenan & Palmer, 2001). But two different coaches can use the same techniques in very different ways indeed; one taking the lead as expert, the other assuming that the client is the expert and following their lead.

Contracting

Life coaching is usually funded by the client him/herself. However, contracting is still important, particularly in relation to boundary issues and what should or should not be included in the coaching agenda. Also, as we have seen, attention needs to be paid to the role of influential others, the client's system, and circles of influence. The main question faced by the person-centred coach is 'Whose agenda am I addressing?' It has to be the client's agenda, and boundaries must be set clearly in place when the contract is with an organization. Issues could arise from lack of clarity in contracting or lack of alignment between client and organizational goals. Issues to be considered in relation to person-centred coaching include understanding the client system and particularly influential others who may undermine the coaching process. Confidentiality may also be an issue within an organization. Unless otherwise agreed, it would be usual for details of the coach–client relationship to remain confidential, and when such details are shared with the organization it would be at the agreement of the client, who would in most cases be given the opportunity to discuss the report and to agree with the coach that it provides a fair representation.

CONTEXTS

The person-centred approach is most obviously applicable to life coaching. Often, clients come knowing that they want to change the direction of their lives, but are struggling to hear their inner voice about the best way to move forward. The person-centred coach can help the person think through relationship choices, managing stressful situations, and so on. Person-centred coaching is ideally suited for the exploration of values, beliefs and assumptions.

As such, the person-centred approach is also well suited to career coaching and helping individuals to discover what they really want to do in their working lives and develop a strategy to achieve it. Where this is most suitable is with clients who have the relevant information but are struggling to choose their direction. A further area of applicability is mentoring in which the person-centred approach serves to build up self-direction.

But the skills of the person-centred coach are also applicable to a wide range of contexts. The person-centred approach, because of its grounding in the idea of intrinsic motivation, is also useful to developmental work in which the client is interested in making new decisions, understanding their values and beliefs, becoming authentic or discovering new purpose. This can be appropriate in an organizational context, although one issue of relevance to person-centred coaches is that because of their principled stance of non-directivity, and going with the client's direction, it becomes less appropriate when commissioned by organizations that have particular goals in mind for the client. The person-centred coach will always stay with the agenda of the client, and this can be problematic if they are employed by an organization whose goals are different from those of the client.

The same issue is pertinent in executive and leadership coaching where often the focus is on organizational performance. Insofar as the client is also focused on organizational aims, the person-centred coach will stay with that agenda, but they would not see it as their task to stay with that agenda if the client's agenda shifted. This may seem a disadvantage, and certainly it would be in terms of organizational performance requirements, such as learning new analytical and business skills. What can result, however, is that clients move away from their organizational agenda towards a more personal agenda in a way which is actually beneficial to them in terms of self-understanding and developing social and emotional skills, which in turn has a knock-on effect in terms of decision making and the ability to relate to others, which can benefit the organization.

Person-centred coaching is least appropriate to peer coaching, simply because of the depth of personal awareness and psychological mindedness needed by the coach, as well as their attitude of principled non-directivity. Without appropriate experience and training in person-centred theory and practice it is difficult for colleagues to be able to work together effectively in this way. Reflections on current practice, and sharing experiences, can easily spill into advice giving, which although appropriate at times, needs to be done in the context of principled non-directivity. But some basic training grounded in person-centred constructs, such as reflective listening and empathic understanding, can be useful to increase the effectiveness of peer coaches using other approaches; but it would be misleading to call this person-centred as it lacks the full philosophical depth of the approach.

Person-centred coaches come from a variety of backgrounds and although some are able to offer skills and performance coaching related to their own expertise, generally person-centred coaching does not set out to achieve goals against set performance criteria. Where it can be particularly useful however is in the group learning context, in which experienced person-centred coaches can facilitate group interaction in such a way that the group members are better able to focus on identifying their goals and finding ways of working to achieve these, and to consider their shared values and discuss what is important to them.

EVALUATION OF PERSON-CENTRED COACHING

Within western culture, mainstream psychological approaches adopt medical model-based approaches in which the therapist or coach is expert. In contrast, the person-centred approach requires the ability of the coach to adopt a non-directive attitude in which the client knows best. Thus, the person-centred approach is often seen as limited because people may come seeking help expecting the therapist or coach to take the expert role. As a result some people find the person-centred approach frustrating, as they are not given solutions to their problems and helped to formulate their difficulties from the medical model perspective. Similarly, some coaches also find the approach limited. There is no one version of what coaching is. Coaching,

like counselling, is divided down the middle on the issue of directivity, with some emphasizing the role of the coach as expert-advice giver and others advocating the ‘ask not tell’ approach (Grant, 2008). But it is no use to argue over which of these is right. Certainly there are some contexts in which people want simply to learn new skills, and directive coaching from an expert is called for; then there are other contexts in which what is to be learned is deeper self-understanding and self-determination. In these latter contexts, how one chooses to work with other people is a matter of philosophical principle. As Schmid (2005) wrote:

Non-directivity is thus a matter of basic beliefs. People who think that directivity is necessary in therapy and counselling have a different image of the human being, a different concept of how to deal with knowledge and a different ethical stance from those who work with their clients on the basis of non-directiveness. Since it is of no use to argue over beliefs (they precede acting, thinking, and science), there is no way to say who, ultimately, is right. (Schmid, 2005:82)

The emergence of the coaching movement has served to reinvigorate interest in the person-centred approach. As mentioned previously, many coaching practitioners describe themselves as using a person-centred approach, and certainly the general ethos of the person-centred approach, that clients are the best experts on themselves, is one that is readily accepted by the coaching community. Grant (2008), for example argues that coaching should be collaborative and client-centred. But it is probably true to say that many who do describe themselves as using the person-centred approach, particularly those who combine it with other approaches, do so in a watered down way in which they may emphasize the quality of the coach–client relationship as being important, but do not fully appreciate the depth of the philosophical underpinnings of the approach.

The person-centred approach provides a robust theoretical system for defining and understanding psychological process – including both those that limit and those that enhance the person. Traditionally person-centred psychology has been conceptualized as part of the wider humanistic psychology. But in recent years, there has been a new field of research and practice, referred to as positive psychology (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). Like person-centred psychology (Rogers, 1957b), positive psychologists are interested in the ‘good life’, arguing that mainstream psychology has been overly concerned with distress and dysfunction at the expense of well-being and optimal functioning. The idea that human beings have an inherent tendency toward growth, development, and optimal functioning has become a focus for theory and research within the new movement of positive psychology (Joseph & Linley, 2006b), and offers an alternative vision to that of the medical model for how we might socially construct what it is to be human.

The strongest support for this comes from self-determination theory (SDT). SDT is a more contemporary organismic theory of human motivation and personality functioning, developed over the past 30 years, that also emphasizes the central role of the individual’s inner resources for personality development and behavioural self-regulation (Deci & Ryan, 2002; Ryan & Deci, 2002). In accord with person-centred theory, SDT views the person as an active growth-oriented organism, attempting to actualize his or her potentialities within the environment in which he

or she functions. The organismic tendency toward actualization is seen as one pole of a dialectical interface, the other pole being the social environment which can be either facilitating or inhibiting of the person's synthesizing tendency (Ryan & Deci, 2002; Deci & Vansteenkiste, 2004; Vansteenkiste & Sheldon, 2006). Similarities between person-centred theory and self-determination theory have been obscured by the differences in terminology and separate research trajectories, but on examination there are such close similarities between these approaches that the extensive research evidence from SDT can be read as providing evidence consistent with person-centred theory (Patterson & Joseph, 2007). Thus, when we examine this weight of theory and evidence we see a real rapprochement between positive psychology and the person-centred approach. Sheldon and Elliot (1999) wrote:

along with Rogers (1961), we believe that individuals have innate developmental trends and propensities that may be given voice by an organismic valuing process occurring within them. The voice can be very difficult to hear, but the current research suggests that the ability to hear it is of crucial importance for the pursuit of happiness. (Sheldon & Elliott, 1999: 495)

Previously, I have argued that the distinction between counselling and coaching implicitly condones the medical model view (Joseph, 2006). As already emphasized, the person-centred perspective provides a unitary way of working with clients along the spectrum of functioning. Within the person-centred perspective, regardless of where the person starts, coaching can be valuable to all. This is not a new idea within person-centred practice. As Shlien, one of the founders of person-centred psychology, said in a talk originally given in 1956:

if the skills developed in psychological counselling can release the constructive capacities of malfunctioning people so that they become healthier, this same help should be available to healthy people who are less than *fully* functioning. If we ever turn towards positive goals of health, we will care less about where the person begins, and more about how to achieve the desired endpoint of the positive goals. (Shlien, 2003: 26)

Person-centred coaching is based on the philosophical assumption that the client is their own best expert and has an intrinsic motivation towards growth, development, and optimal functioning, and that this will be given expression when the client's psychological processes are trusted and encouraged in the context of a facilitative person-to-person relationship.

FURTHER READING

- Joseph, S., & Linley, P.A. (2006). *Positive therapy: A meta-theory for positive psychological practice*. London: Routledge. (In this book, we discuss the alternative meta-theoretical paradigm of person-centred theory and how it can provide the underpinning to positive psychology, therapy, and coaching.)
- Rogers, C.R. (1959). *A theory of therapy, personality, and interpersonal relationships as developed in the client-centered framework*. In S. Koch (Ed.), *Psychology: A study of a Science: Formulations of the person and the social context* (Vol. 3, pp.184–256). New York: McGraw-Hill. (This is the most sophisticated theoretical statement of the person-centred tradition in which Rogers attempted to show how the approach was applicable to a range of contexts, setting out in detail the theoretical propositions that remain the core of the approach today.)

Rogers, C.R. (1980). *A Way of Being*. Boston, MA: Houghton Mifflin Co. (This book brings together some of Rogers's personal and philosophical writings. As such it provides a good introduction to the later writings of Rogers and the wider applications of the person-centred approach, including to contexts that we would today recognize as coaching.)

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